How to Build a Computer

An expert-approved guide on crafting a computer from scratch

Co-authored by Matt Ham and **Eric McClure**

Last Updated: September 5, 2026 ☑ **Fact Checked**

This wikiHow teaches you how to build a desktop computer using custom parts. Successfully building a computer is largely contingent on defining your computer goals and budget, choosing the right parts, and putting everything together in the correct order. To help, we spoke with computer repair specialist Matt Ham to get the lowdown on building a PC the right way.

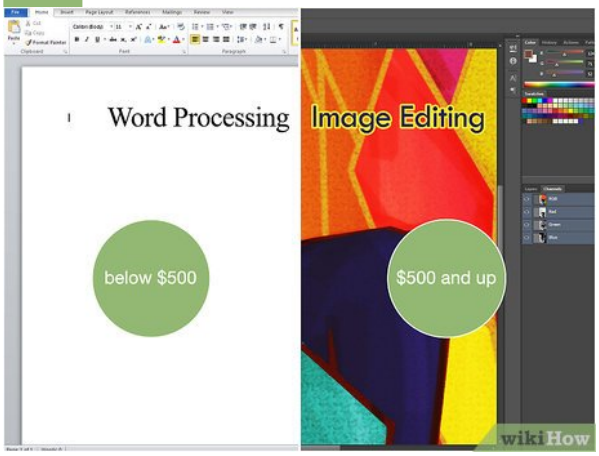
How to Make a Computer

Plan your PC build by identifying what you're going to use the computer for and how much you want to spend. Compose a parts list and buy the individual components. When it's time to build, start with the motherboard, CPU, and RAM. Move on to the cooler, storage, and GPU before installing the fans.

Part 1

Part 1 of 4:

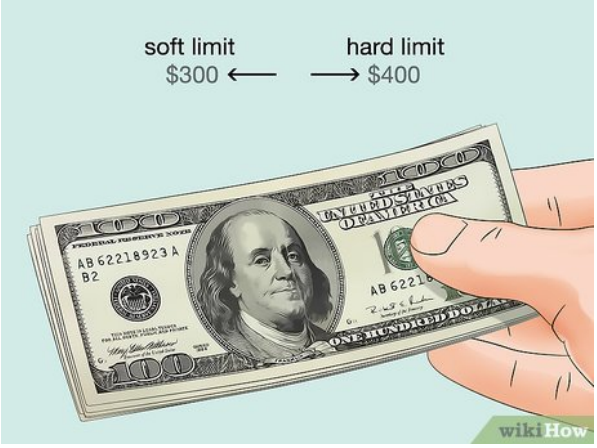
Planning Your Build



1 **Determine your computer's primary use.** Before you buy any components or establish a budget, start by identifying what the computer is for. Standard desktop PCs which are used for things like browsing and simple programs (e.g., Microsoft Word and Excel) can use older, less expensive parts, while gaming- or editing computers will require powerful, up-to-date parts.[1]

Note: You can expect to spend under $400-500 US for most basic desktops. Gaming and editing computers may run you anywhere from $500-5,000.

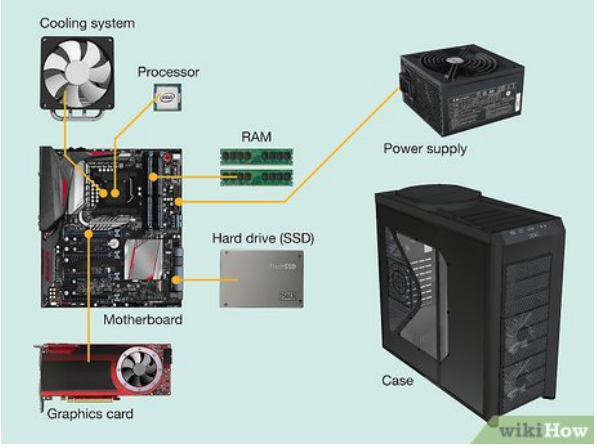
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2 **Establish a budget for your PC.** Matt Ham points out that it's too easy to start buying attractive parts without sticking to a budget, only to realize that you're out of money and don't have all of the necessary equipment to build your PC. Figure out a soft limit (e.g., $300) and a hard limit (e.g., $400) and try to stay within that range.[2]

- Common sense should guide your purchasing as well. For example, if the processor for which you budget is $100 but a nicer, newer model is discounted from $200 to $120 at your local tech store, spending the extra $20 is probably a better long-term investment.

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3 **Learn the basics about each part you have to buy.** No matter how expensive your computer is, you will need the following components for your project:[3]

- **Processor (CPU)** — This is the "brain" of your computer. In most builds, the CPU is the second-most expensive component.
- **CPU Cooler** — The CPU requires dedicated cooling to avoid overheating. You can use an air cooler, which is cheaper, or an AIO (all-in-one) cooler that uses antifreeze to liquid cool the chip.
- **Motherboard** — This serves as the interface between all of your computer's components and the processor. It's sort of like the foundation of a home.
- **RAM** — Random Access Memory. RAM increases your computer's performance by handling short-term memory and data storage. The more RAM you have, the more complex tasks your computer can perform.
- **Storage Drives (HDD or SSD)** — These store data. You can buy a traditional hard disk drive (HDD), or a slightly more expensive solid-state drive (SSD). These days, SSDs are relatively cheap and usually worth the extra spend.
- **Power supply** — This powers all of your computer's individual components. This is what you plug into the wall socket.
- **Graphics card (GPU)** — This renders images on your computer. Ham explains that while most processors have a built-in graphics processing unit (GPU), buying a dedicated graphics card is essential if you plan on doing anything beyond web browsing.[4]
- **Fans** — This includes case fans and coolers for specific parts and keeps the inside of your case at a safe temperature.
- **Case** — This is necessary for storing and cooling your components.

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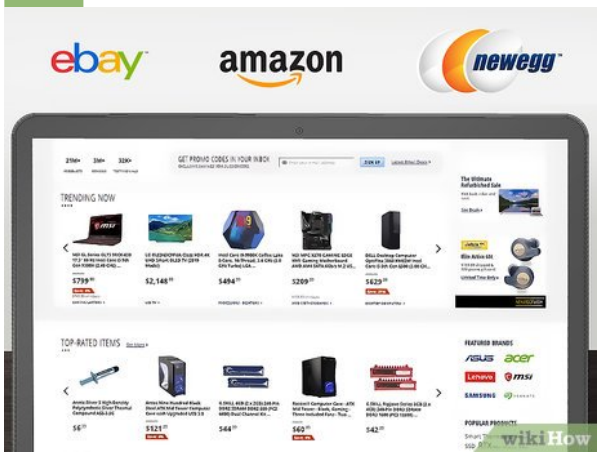
4 **Use PC Part Picker to craft your components list as you go.** PC Part Picker is basically essential these days. It allows PC builders to list the components they want to buy so that they confirm everything is compatible. The site also allows you to track the prices of each component so you can ensure you get the best deal.[5]

- As you choose the components you want, add them to your build. If you ever change your mind, just swap the piece out on your list and reconfirm the build is compatible (PC Part Picker will tell you if it isn't).
- PC Part Picker is 100% free.
- PC Part Picker is also a great place to start if you have *zero* idea which RAM cards you want or which CPU is ideal, etc. The site pulls performance data and component popularity for every potential component.

Part 2

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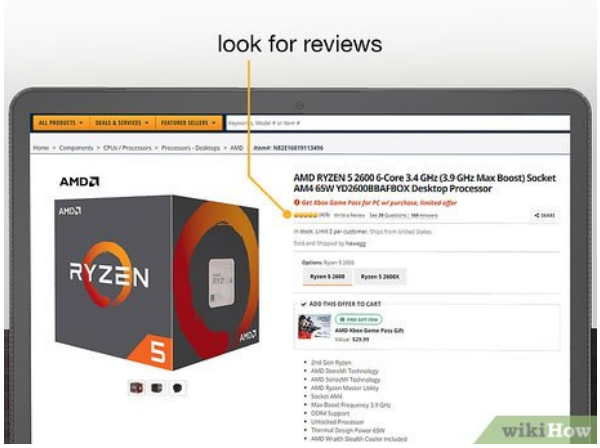
Buying the Components



1 **Buy your components over time to get the best deal.** In-store locations such as Best Buy will stock computer components, but you can usually find comparable parts for cheaper if you shop online. Common online locations include Amazon, eBay, and NewEgg. If you want the best prices, wait for sales on the individual component in your list—you'd be surprised how often parts go on sale.[6]

- Waiting for sales (e.g. Black Friday Sales) can often pay off, as parts can be heavily discounted, allowing you to either save money or opt for better components for the same price.
- Some online retailers may offer a 'free shipping' deal if you spend a certain amount of money. Consider buying enough parts from those sites to save on shipping, which is often expensive. This doesn't mean you should pay more for components cheaper elsewhere though!

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2 **Research every component you intend to purchase.** Ham explains that you should read online consumer review sites for more information. Remember, this is one of the most important steps, because everything will depend on your hardware working correctly and together.[7]

- As you get more in the reeds, you may want to check out: How to Build a Cheap Gaming Computer, How to Choose Components for Building a Computer, and How to Build a Powerful Quiet Computer.
- The most reputable hardware reviewers around today include Linus Tech Tips, Tom's Hardware, and Gamer's Nexus.
- Once you've found a decently reviewed component, look for negative reviews of the component. You may find that the component is great for certain uses, but inappropriate for your own preferences.

EXPERT TIP



Hannah Dillon
wikiHow Technology Writer

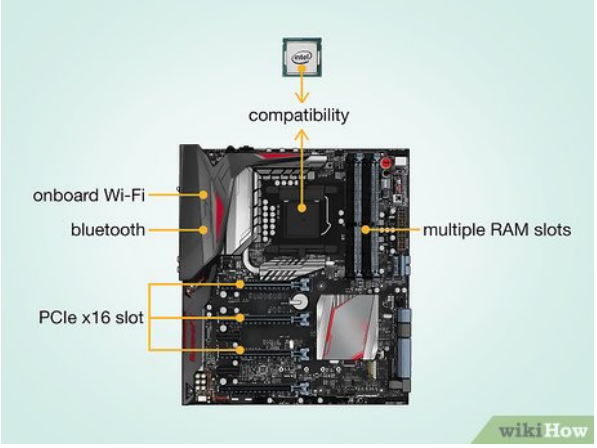
"If you're new to building computers, use a website like PCPartPicker.com to help ensure all the parts you select will be compatible. Computer parts are expensive, and it's best to make sure all your parts will work together before you start putting your rig together. PCPartPicker can also help you find the lowest prices and discounts for your components as well!"



3 **Choose a CPU with enough power to suit your needs.** The CPU (central processing unit) is the core of your computer's performance. The higher the processor's speed in gigahertz (GHz), the faster it can process data. Many applications use multiple threads at the same time, so more cores can improve performance.[8]

- The processor will usually entail a large part of your budget.
- Processors typically come in quad-core, hexa-core or higher. Unless you're building an ultra-high-performance gaming PC, you should stick to around 6 cores.
- These days, you have two choices for CPUs: **Intel** and **AMD**. AMD's offerings are considered "stronger" but Intel's chips are more compatible with aftermarket software.

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4 **Get a motherboard that fits your CPU.** If you buy an AMD CPU, your motherboard must be designed for AMD chips (and vice versa for Intel). Other aspects to look for in a motherboard include the following:[9]

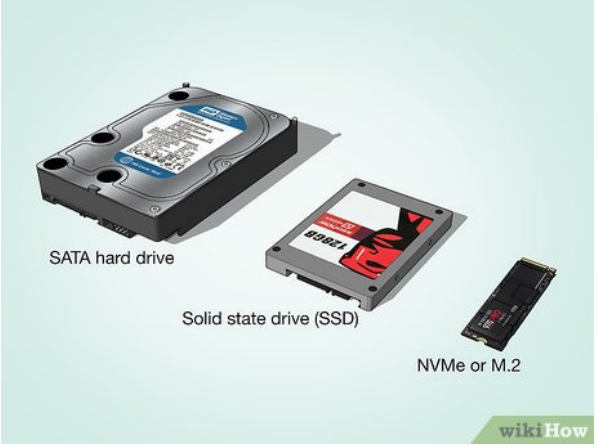
- Onboard Wi-Fi (ensures that your computer will have wireless capabilities)
- Bluetooth
- Multiple RAM slots/high RAM capacity
- Support for graphics cards if necessary (PCIe x16 slot)
- Support for multiple SSD drives (if you want multiple solid-state drives)
- Enough USB slots for the number of fans you want to include



5 **Purchase RAM based on how much multitasking/editing you do.** RAM is responsible for storing data from running programs, so having enough of it is important. Not having enough RAM will be most noticeable under two scenarios: multitasking and flipping between programs, and when you're doing intensive gaming or editing. Before buying RAM, be sure to check both your processor and your motherboard for the type of RAM which is supported.[10]

- **How much RAM do I really need?** 8 GB is plenty for basic web surfing. If you're a gamer, 16 GB is considered the minimum these days. 32 GB is the sweet spot for high-end gaming and multitasking, and 64 GB is only necessary if you're doing a ton of video or audio editing.
- Depending on your motherboard, you'll need to buy either DDR4 RAM or the newer DDR5 RAM. Do not build a PC with DDR3 RAM unless you have zero interest in modern computing programs.
- Due to memory shortage caused by AI, RAM is more expensive today than it was a few years ago. Expect to spend $380 for 32GB DDR5 kit, $220 for 16GB DDR5 kit, and $110 for 16GB DDR4 kit.[11]

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6 **Pick a storage device (SSD or HDD) with enough room for your needs.** Comparatively speaking, purchasing a storage device is easy—most drives are compatible with virtually all motherboards and processors. For this step, choose whether you want a hard disk drive (HDD) or a solid-state drive (SSD).[12]

- **Do I need an SSD or HDD?** SSDs are much faster than traditional HDDs and they're much more reliable. SSDs contain no moving parts so they can't physically fail the way HDDs do. If you're going for a very basic build and don't care about potentially losing your data one day, an HDD is fine. Most users will benefit from upgrading to an SSD, though.
- **What if I'm on a budget but want an SSD?** Find a cheaper, smaller capacity (200-500GB) SSD to use as your boot drive (the drive the operating system runs on). Then, use a larger (500GB-1TB) HDD for files, photos, videos, etc. This makes the computer run much faster than just using a single HDD.
- There are two types of SSD, M2 and SATA drives. M2 cards go right into the face of your motherboard. SATA drives connect to the power supply and then run to a port on the motherboard.



7 **Purchase a GPU with enough juice to run your programs.** A dedicated graphics card (sometimes called a GPU or video card) is essential for playing the latest games, but you can skip the GPU if you buy a CPU with integrated graphics and you only want to browse the web. Most users will want to buy a GPU, though.[13]

- There are three options for GPU manufacturers: **Nvidia**, **AMD**, and **Intel**. Your GPU manufacturer does not have to match the CPU manufacturer. The GPU is the most expensive component, so choose your GPU carefully.
- **How much should I spend on a GPU?** If you want to play brand new games at the highest settings, it's worth splurging on a GPU. If you really don't care about incredible gaming graphics, this is where you can save some money—buy a card from a previous generation. You'll be fine.

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8 **Make sure your power supply can handle the load.** The power supply powers all of your components in your computer. The power supply **must** be powerful enough to power all of your components; don't worry about it being so powerful that you waste electricity by powering more than you need, as it will only output as many watts as you use and the number on its wattage is only its max capacity.[14]

- It's best to buy more watts than you need, as this will make future component upgrades easier.

> **Tip:** Choose a power supply from a reputable manufacturer like Seasonic, beQuiet, EVGA or Corsair. Cheap non-brand-name power supplies are potential fire risks.



9 **Pick up a case that is both functional and easy on the eyes.** The case is what holds your computer components. A few cases come with a power supply included, but if you are making a gaming build then getting a separate power supply is recommended, as the power supplies that come with cases are usually not very high quality.[15]

- The size of the case will be based on how many drives bays and card slots it has, as well as the size and type of your motherboard.
- Be sure to select a case which can fit all of your components, including your hard drive.
- Cases might obstruct air flow causing some higher-end components with larger power draw to overheat.
- If you're looking to save money, this is one area where you can spend a little less and not compromise on performance.
- **A note on cases and high-end GPUs:** Newer GPUs (like the Nvidia 4000 cards) are, to put it frankly, comically gigantic. Double-check the dimensions and clearance room for your GPU in the case if you plan on buying a newer GPU.

Part 3

Part 3 of 4:

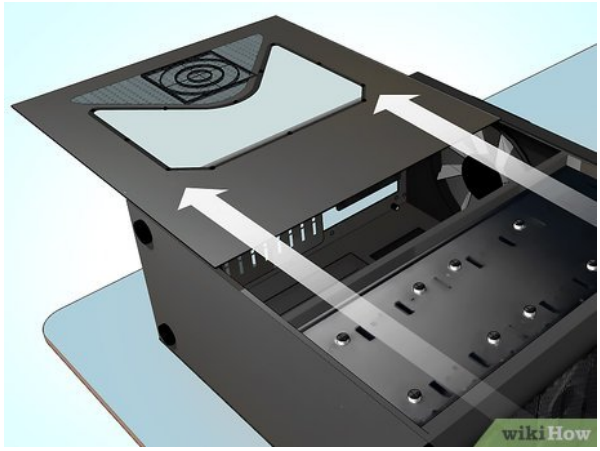
Assembling Your Computer

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1 **Ground yourself to avoid frying a component with static electricity.** Use an antistatic wrist-strap cable to prevent electrostatic discharge (ESD) which can be deadly to computer electronics. Alternatively, touch a large metal body like a radiator to discharge yourself.

- **Don't want to buy a fancy wrist strap?** No worries. Just build your PC on a wood surface with a tile or wood floor. Don't wear socks and avoid carpet. Touch bare metal every 30-45 minutes to discharge any potential static buildup. You should be fine.



2 **Disassemble the case so you can access all the compartments.** Unscrew the side panels (or slide them toward the back of the case). Set them aside. If you can remove the ceiling and floor of the case, do that too.

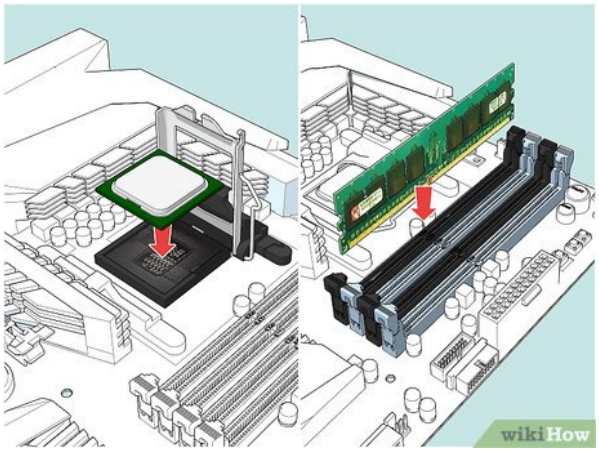
- The actual build process is kind of like putting Legos together—it's not particularly hard since the pieces only snap together if they fit. Fitting those Legos in the case is more like a puzzle where the pieces need to be arranged in a particular way. The more room you have to work, the better.

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3 **Install the power supply but leave the cables aside.** Some cases come with the power supply already installed, while others will require you to purchase the power supply separately and install it yourself. Make sure that the power supply is installed in the correct orientation, and that nothing is blocking the power supply's fans.[16]

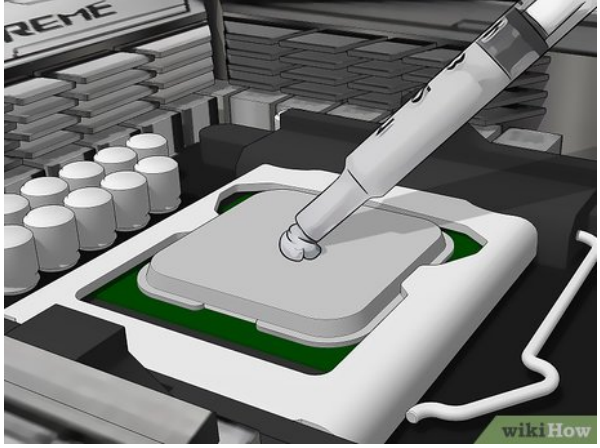
- The power supply will usually go near the top or the bottom rear of the case. You can determine where the power supply is supposed to sit by looking for a missing section on the back of the case.
- Don’t start hooking up the cables. That will be one of the last things you do after putting everything in.



4 **Add the CPU and RAM to the motherboard.** Do this before you install the motherboard in the case, as the case can limit your ability to wire components:[17]

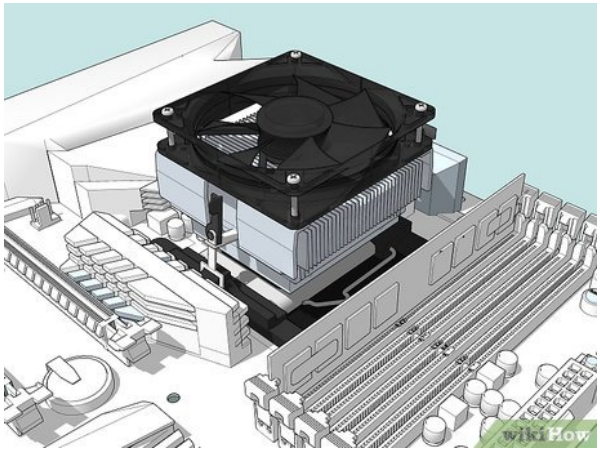
- Attach the CPU to the motherboard by finding the processor port on the motherboard's surface. There is usually a small, golden triangle on the corner of every CPU which matches up with a similar triangle on your motherboard. Line those up and lock the CPU in place by folding down the little metal arm.
  - **Don’t touch the CPU pins!** Only touch the CPU by holding the rim. If you touch the gold pins that go into the motherboard, you could bend them and ruin the CPU.
- Attach your RAM to the motherboard by finding the RAM slots and inserting the RAM appropriately (they should only fit one way).

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5 **Apply thermal paste to the CPU (if necessary).** Put a small dot (around the size of a grain of rice or a pea) of thermal paste on the CPU. Adding too much thermal paste will create a mess, such as getting paste into the motherboard socket, which may short circuit components and decrease the motherboard's value if you plan to sell it later.[18]

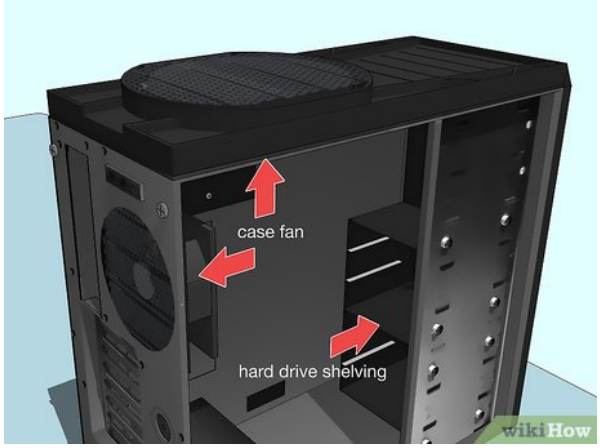
> **Tip:** Some processors that come with heat sinks do not need thermal paste because the heat sink already has thermal paste applied by the factory. Check the bottom of the heat sink unit before applying paste to the processor.



6 **Attach the CPU cooler on top of the CPU.** This varies from cooler to cooler, so read the instructions for your processor. Most coolers attach directly over the processor and screw into the motherboard. Some coolers may have brackets that need to be attached underneath the motherboard.[19]

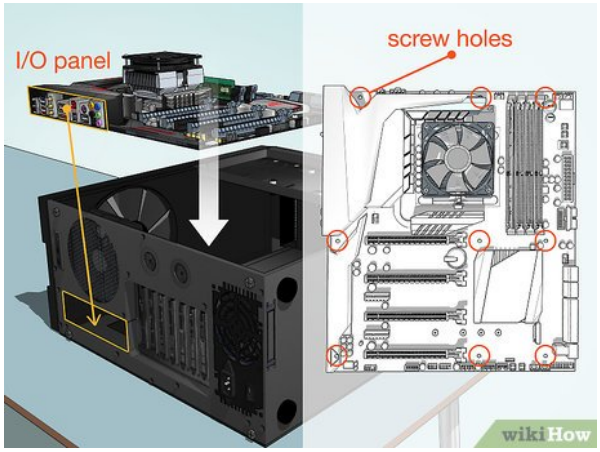
- **Installing an air cooler:** Orient the cooler so that the fan blows in your preferred location (usually to the back of the case). Install the 4 screws and tighten them.
- **Installing an AIO:** Install the radiator first by securing it to your case. Then, connect the CPU block with the 4 screws.
  - **Important safety note on AIOs:** The hoses for the AIO must feed up from the CPU. If you install the AIO under the CPU (or upside down on the front of the case), air bubbles will accumulate in the hoses and your CPU will overheat.

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7 **Prepare your case.** You may need to knock the plates out of the back of the case in order to fit your components into the correct positions.

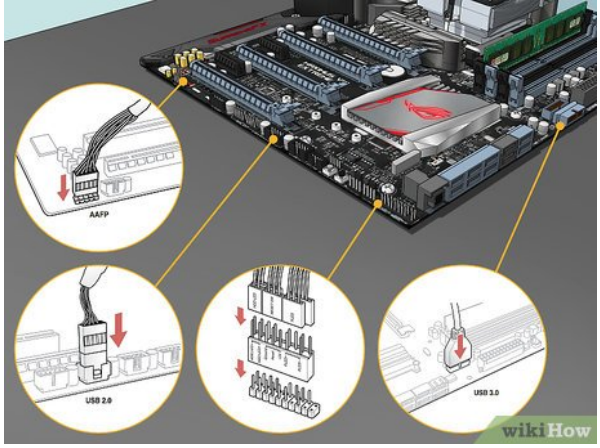
- If your case has separate shelving units to hold your hard drive, install the units using the included screws.
- You may need to install and wire your case's fans before you can install any components. If so, follow your case's fan installation instructions.



8 **Secure the motherboard to the case.** Once the standoffs are installed, place the motherboard in the case and push it up against the backplate. All of the back ports should fit into the holes in the I/O backplate.

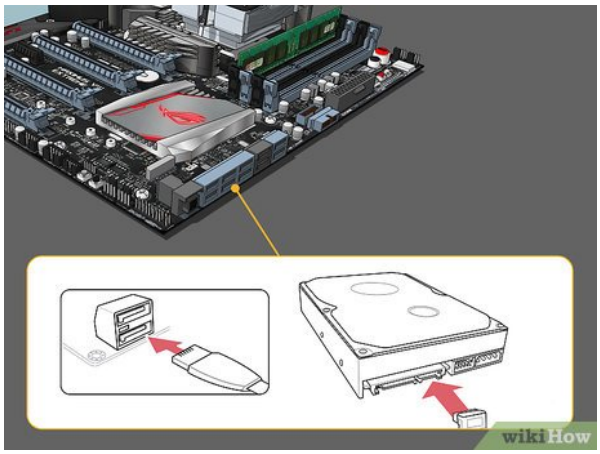
- Use the screws provided to secure the motherboard to the standoffs through the shielded screw holes on the motherboard.
- **Now you can start hooking up power supply cables.** You can start connecting the SATA and USB cables whenever it makes the most sense to you. With the motherboard in the case, the foundation of the computer is in place and the order of operations is up to you.

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9 **Plug in the case connectors to the motherboard.** These tend to be located together on the motherboard near the front of the case. The order in which these are connected will depend on which is easiest. Make sure that you connect the USB ports, the Power and Reset switches, the LED power and hard drive lights, and the audio cable. Your motherboard's documentation will show you where on your motherboard these connectors attach.[20]

- **What if something doesn't fit?** There is typically only one way that these connectors can attach to the motherboard. Don't try to force anything to fit. The pins of these connectors are often very thin and delicate, so if something doesn't slot automatically into place, it's probably not meant to be there.



10 **Install your SSD and/or HDD storage devices.** This process will vary slightly depending on your case and the type of drive, but should typically go as follows:[21]

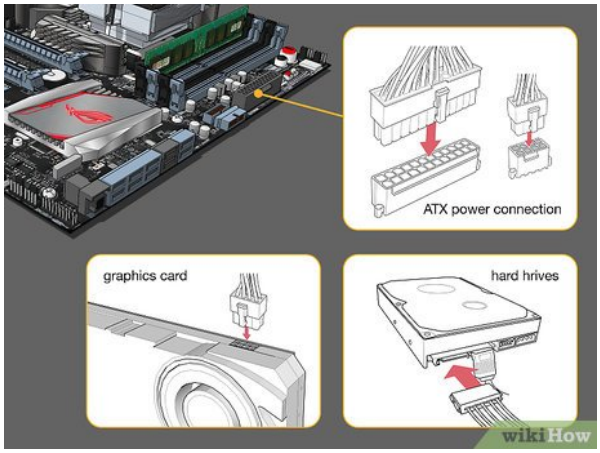
- Plug any **SATA SSD** drive's SATA cable into the SATA slot on the motherboard. Tuck the SATA SSD anywhere it seems like it'd fit safely.
- Connect any **HDD** to the motherboard with a SATA cable. Tuck the HDD into any slot on the back of the case.
- If you're using an **M.2 SSD**, slot this into the motherboard and screw it down to the small post on the end opposite to the slot. Many motherboards have heatsinks over M.2 slots, so make sure you remove any plastic backing after installing your drive and replacing the heatsink.

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11 **Slot the GPU into the motherboard.** Remove any plastic backing or covers from the GPU. Locate the GPU slot (called a PCIe slot) below the CPU and RAM. Open the brackets on the sides of the slot and slowly insert the GPU's connector. Once you hear a snapping noise, the GPU is seated.[22]

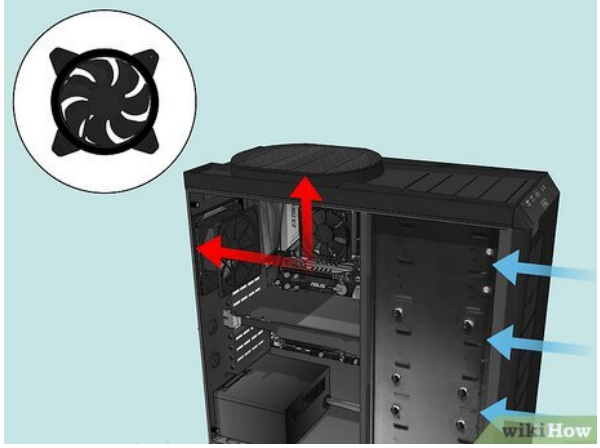
- If you have a newer GPU, you will also need to connect a PSU cable to the front of the card to power it.



12 **Connect the power supply to the remaining components.** If you haven't already connected the power supply to components which need power, make sure that it is connected to the following locations:

- Motherboard. This is connected with the largest plug: a (usually) 24 pin connector.
- Graphics card(s). These draw 75W of power from the PCIe slot on the motherboard, but may require additional power in the form of 6 or 8 pin connectors on the card.
- Storage devices. These connect with SATA cables to both the power supply and motherboard.

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13 **Install the fans inside of your case last.** The fans are easily the most frustrating part of PC building if you have more than 2-3 of them. The blades must be oriented so that you get the airflow you want, and each fan has two cables (if they have RGB capabilities). Take your time to screw in all of the fans and connect them to the relevant ports on the motherboard.[23]

- **A note on airflow:** As a rule of thumb, you want some fans for intake to blow cold air into the case, and some fans for outtake to remove hot air from the case. Usually, builders put outtake fans in the back and top of the case since hot air rises. Intake goes in the front or bottom (or both).



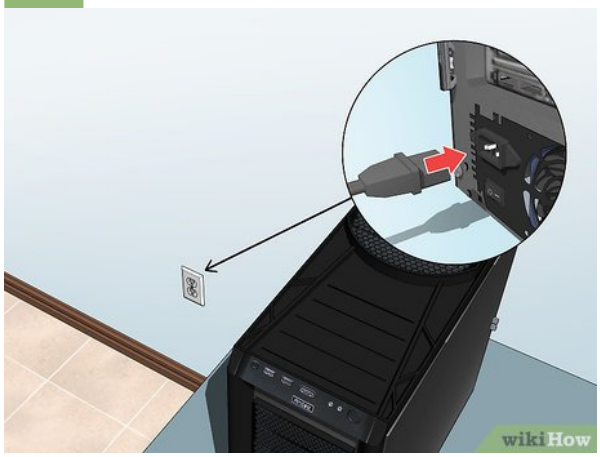
14 **Finish your computer assembly and reassemble the case.** Once you've placed and connected the various internal components for your computer, all that's left to do is ensure that none of the wires interfere with circulation and close up the case.[24]

- Many cases will have a panel that either slides back into place or screws onto the side of the case.

Part 4

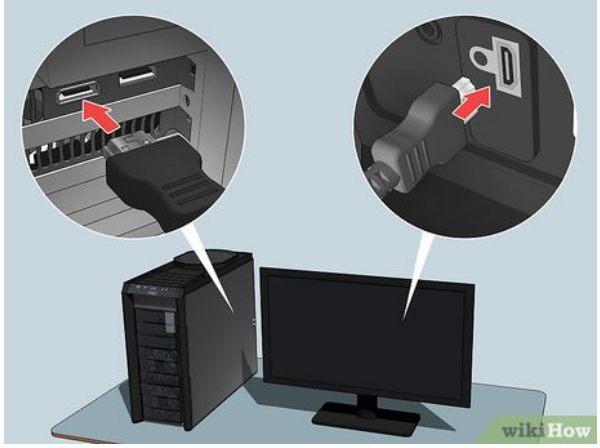
Part 4 of 4:

Powering Your Computer



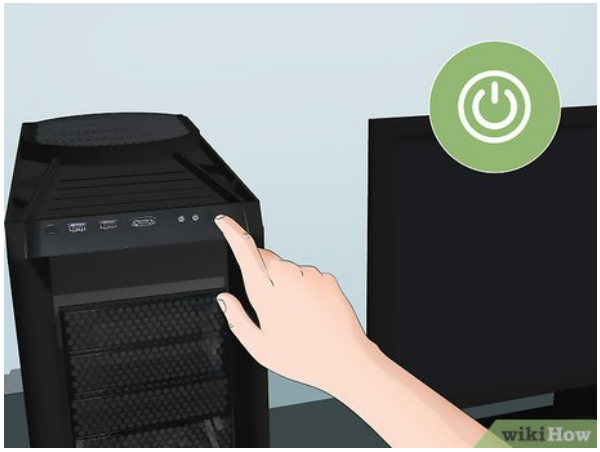
1 **Attach your computer to an outlet.** Using your power source's power cable, plug your computer into a wall outlet or power strip. You may first have to attach the electrical cable to the power source input on the back of your computer's case.[25]

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2 **Plug a monitor into your computer.** You'll typically use the graphics card output that's near the bottom of the case, though some motherboards may have this port on the right or left side of the case.[26]

- The output here is usually a DisplayPort or HDMI port.



3 **Turn on your computer.** Press the computer's **Power** button on the front or back of the case. If everything's properly connected, your computer should start up.[27]

> **Tip:** If you encounter issues during the startup process—or if your computer fails to start—disconnect it from the power source, re-open the case, and check the connections again. Also make sure that the switch on the power supply is set to 'On', usually denoted by a 'I' symbol.



4 **Install Windows or Linux.** Windows is compatible basically all PCs and will make full use of their various features (e.g., Bluetooth), but you will have to purchase a copy of Windows if you don't have a product key. Linux is becoming more and more popular, and offers a free alternative to Windows.[28]

- If you don't have an installation USB drive, you'll need to create one on another computer before you can install your operating system.

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5 **Install your drivers.** Once your operating system is installed, you will need to install your drivers. Almost all of the hardware that you purchased should come with discs that contain the driver software needed for the hardware to work, although it's usually better to search for the relevant drivers online and download those, as the discs are usually old and outdated, by the time you receive them.[29]

- Modern versions of Windows and Linux will install most drivers automatically when connected to the Internet.
- And if the steps above have been helpful, be sure to download this article as a PDF so you can print, read, or reference it any time.

Download PDF for $2.99

Community Q&A

Question

Where can I get price comparisons for computer parts?

Community Answer

Use a website called PCpartpicker.com It will help you choose compatible parts and also determine the cheapest website to buy from.

Helpful 405 Not Helpful 54

Question

How do I install an OS?

Community Answer

Because most OSs nowadays are booted from USBs, you will need to change the start-up order (in BIOS) to start from the USB. There will usually be on-screen instructions aiding you with installing your OS.

Helpful 48 Not Helpful 11

Question

Is it possible to get Windows without having to insert a disc into your optical drive? If yes, how?

Community Answer

Windows 10 purchased from a store or online comes on flash drive now, all you have to do is plug in the flash drive and boot from that. You can also download the ISO and, using Microsoft USB Download Tool software, create your own bootable installation flash drive if you have a spare.

Helpful 157 Not Helpful 45

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Tips

- Each power supply cable will only fit in the correct orientation, but pressure will still be needed to push the cables in. If using a newer power supply with an 8-pin EPS 12V connector and a PCI Express 8-pin connector, don't attempt to force the cables into place.
- Some components will come with protective plastic on them so they aren't scratched up. Make sure you remove this or you computer will start to smell like burning plastic.
- If you install a water cooling system instead of a typical fan, you should run a 24-hour test to check for leaks before actually installing it in your computer.

Tips from our Readers

- Do research on your components before buying a power supply to make sure it will have enough power for all the components. It's also a good idea to buy a bigger power supply than you need, in case you decide to upgrade components in the future.

Warnings

- Use care when working around the sharp, sheet metal edges of a computer case. It is easy to cut yourself, especially with very small cases.
- Avoid electrostatic discharge when installing components. Wear a static wristband or regularly ground yourself by touching a metal part of the case before handling components.
- Don't touch the resistors and the pins on the CPU or the socket.
- Do not buy any computer parts from any untrusted retailer online; you might get scammed, or the computer part may be defective.
- Make sure all parts are compatible with your motherboard!
- Be sure to buy a power supply with the specific needs for your system and from a reputable company, as cheaper ones can be faulty and completely damage your system.
- Wash your hands before building a computer.

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About This Article



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This article was co-authored by Matt Ham and by wikiHow staff writer, Eric McClure. Matt Ham is a Computer Repair Specialist and the CEO and President of Computer Repair Doctor. With over a decade of experience, Matt specializes in Mac, PC, iPhone, iPad, and Smartphone repairs and upgrades. Matt holds a BS in Mechanical Engineering from North Carolina State University and an MS in Mechanical Engineering from Columbia University. Matt has expanded Computer Repair Doctor to seven different locations. He is also a Co-Owner of Repair Life, a full-scale marketing agency specializing in driving both online and offline leads to cell phone and computer repair shops and device retailers. This article has been viewed 2,437,913 times.

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